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MULTIMEDIA DESIGN WSEEK 12

1. **Empathy & Analysis Report: Screen Reader Experience**

For this exercise, I used a screen reader (NVDA on Windows) to navigate a website I frequently use: YouTube. The goal was to understand how visually impaired users interact with digital content and identify usability challenges.

At the start, the experience was immediately different from normal browsing. Instead of visually scanning the page, I had to rely entirely on audio feedback and keyboard navigation. NVDA reads out headings, links, and buttons, but navigating through the homepage felt overwhelming. There were many repeated elements such as "link," "button," and "thumbnail," making it difficult to quickly understand the structure of the page.

One major barrier I encountered was poor labeling of elements. Many buttons, especially icons (like "like," "share," or "subscribe"), were either vaguely described or not clearly differentiated. This made it confusing to know exactly what action I was selecting. Another issue was navigation inefficiency. Moving through content required repeatedly pressing keys to cycle through items, which was time-consuming compared to visually clicking. Additionally, dynamic content such as autoplay previews and ads disrupted the flow, as the screen reader would suddenly shift focus or read unexpected information.

This experience significantly changed my perspective on design. I realized that what seems visually obvious—like layout, color, and icons—does not translate well for screen reader users. Accessibility is not just about adding features; it requires intentional design that ensures clarity, structure, and consistency. It also made me appreciate how frustrating and exhausting poor design can be for users relying on assistive technologies.

Based on this experience, I propose three specific improvements:

1. **Improve Labeling and Alt Text:** All buttons and interactive elements should have clear, descriptive labels. For example, instead of just "button," it should say "Subscribe to channel" or "Like this video."
2. **Enhance Keyboard Navigation:** The site should allow users to skip repetitive sections (like menus or ads) easily, using shortcut keys or "skip to content" options.
3. **Reduce Dynamic Interruptions:** Autoplay features and pop-ups should be minimized or made optional, as they disrupt the reading flow and confuse screen reader users.

Overall, this exercise highlighted the importance of inclusive design. By improving accessibility, websites can become more usable for everyone, not just those with disabilities.

2. **Usability Test Plan**

1. Objective of the Test

The objective of this usability test is to evaluate how easily users can navigate my final course project website and complete key tasks. The focus is on identifying usability issues related to navigation, content clarity, and overall user experience. I want to determine whether users can efficiently find information and interact with features without confusion or assistance.

2. Test Participant

The test was conducted with one participant who has basic experience using websites but is not familiar with my project. This helps simulate a first-time user experience.

3. Tasks for Participants

The participant was asked to complete the following tasks:

- **Task 1:** Navigate to the homepage and describe what the website is about.
- **Task 2:** Find the contact information (email or contact form).
- **Task 3:** Locate and play the introductory video (if available).
- **Task 4:** Find a specific section (e.g., services, products, or features).
- **Task 5:** Attempt to complete a key action (e.g., sign up, submit a form, or make a selection).

4. Post-Test Questions

After completing the tasks, I asked the participant the following questions:

1. What was your first impression of the website?
2. Did you find it easy or difficult to navigate? Why?
3. Were there any parts that confused you?
4. How long did it take you to find the information you needed?
5. What improvements would you suggest?

5. Summary of Findings

The participant was able to complete most of the tasks, but with some difficulty. They quickly understood the purpose of the website from the homepage, which indicates that the main message is clear. However, they struggled to find the contact information, as it was not prominently displayed. This suggests that important elements need better visibility.

Navigation was another issue. The participant hesitated when looking for specific sections, indicating that the menu labels may not be clear enough. Additionally, they mentioned that some buttons were not obvious, which slowed down task completion.

On a positive note, the design was described as visually appealing and simple, which made the experience less overwhelming. However, usability could be improved by making key features more accessible.

6. Recommendations

Based on the findings, I recommend:

- Making contact information more visible (e.g., placing it in the header or footer).
- Improving navigation labels to be clearer and more intuitive.
- Highlighting important buttons to make them stand out.

Overall, the test revealed that while the website is functional, small design improvements can significantly enhance user experience.